

Executive Skills Reference

A concise reference defining the eight core executive function skills relevant to early childhood education.

From *UDL for Little Learners: Practical Strategies for Early Childhood Educators* by Jeff Horwitz · udlforlittlelearners.com

Executive Skill Resource

Executive function is the umbrella term for the cognitive skills that help us manage our thoughts, actions, and emotions to achieve goals — things like impulse control, working memory, and cognitive flexibility. Our youngest learners are just beginning to build these skills, and moments like transitions, packing up, and writing are where they're tested most. Part of our role as teachers is to provide the right scaffolds and supports to help students develop them.

Below are the eight core executive skills referenced throughout *UDL for Little Learners*, defined with early childhood examples.

Working Memory

The ability to hold and work with information in mind — like remembering a set of instructions while carrying them out.

Inhibitory Control (Impulse Control)

The ability to stop and think before acting — like waiting for your turn during circle time.

Cognitive Flexibility (Shifting)

The ability to shift thinking or attention — like moving from one activity to another without frustration.

Planning

The ability to think ahead and create steps to reach a goal — like deciding what materials to gather before starting an art project.

Organization

The ability to keep track of materials and information — like putting supplies back in the right spot.

Initiation

The ability to begin a task independently — like starting homework or tidying up a play area.

Self-Monitoring

The ability to check your own work and behavior — like re-reading a sentence to see if it makes sense.

Emotional Regulation

The ability to manage emotions in different situations — like calming down after a disagreement with a peer.